

TRAIL RESOURCE CONDITION ASSESSMENT GUIDE

Version: v2.3

Effective Date: March 15, 2026

Issued by: Glacier National Park Resource Management - Personal Reference Copy

Prepared for: Field Staff Personal Use

PURPOSE

This guide provides condition codes and recommended management responses for trail surface and corridor assessments conducted during personal field surveys. Use this guide together with photographic documentation to assign the correct condition classification for each surveyed trail segment.

CONDITION CODE REFERENCE TABLE

CODE 1 - STABLE

Visual indicators: Trail surface intact with no visible erosion indicators.

Tread is firm and compacted. No ruts, root exposure, or active channeling.

Recommended action: No action required. Monitor at next routine survey.

Escalation required: No

CODE 2 - MINOR WEAR

Visual indicators: Visible surface wear including minor scuffing, slight

tread widening, or shallow ruts less than 5 cm deep. No active water

channeling. Gravel displacement present but tread surface still functional.

Recommended action: Monitor at next survey. Consider seasonal hardening if wear trend continues across two consecutive surveys.

Escalation required: No

CODE 3 - MODERATE EROSION

Visual indicators: Active surface erosion visible. Ruts between 5 and 15 cm

deep, exposed roots or rocks forming tread obstacles, or early-stage cross-

trail channel formation present. Tread surface is functional but degrading.

Recommended action: Schedule trail maintenance within the current season.

Flag segment for work crew assignment. Document with photographs.

Escalation required: No

CODE 4 - ACTIVE EROSION

Visual indicators: Deep ruts exceeding 15 cm, significant root undercutting,

active water channeling across tread, visible headwall formation, or slope

creep affecting tread alignment. Trail safety is compromised for general visitor use.

Recommended action: Restrict use to foot traffic only pending maintenance.

Initiate supervisor notification and submit maintenance work order within 48 hours of survey date.

Escalation required: YES - supervisor notification required within 48 hours

CODE 5 - SEVERE DAMAGE

Visual indicators: Trail tread is impassable or structurally unsafe. Major

slope failure, significant trail loss, structural damage to drainage features,

or conditions presenting immediate visitor safety hazard.

Recommended action: Close trail segment immediately pending emergency

assessment. Contact supervisor for emergency response protocol. Post closure notices at all trailhead access points.
Escalation required: YES - immediate supervisor notification required

ESCALATION THRESHOLD

Condition codes 4 and 5 require supervisor notification. Assessor must document findings in writing and route to area supervisor within 48 hours of survey completion. Include survey date, segment identifier, photographic evidence, and assigned condition code in all escalation notifications.

PHOTOGRAPHIC EVIDENCE RULE

When photographic evidence and written field impressions conflict, photographic evidence takes precedence over written field notes in all condition classifications. Photographs capture current observable conditions at the time of survey and serve as the primary documentation record. Written impressions recorded in the field prior to full photo review should be treated as preliminary only and must be verified against photographic documentation before any condition code is finalized.

SURVEY DOCUMENTATION REQUIREMENTS

For each surveyed segment, record the following in the trail condition log:

- Segment identifier
- Assigned condition code from this guide
- Recommended action as stated for that code
- Assessor name
- Survey date
- Standards version used (record "v2.3" for this edition)
- Escalation flag (Yes or No per escalation threshold above)
- Brief notes on observed features if relevant

VERSION HISTORY

v2.3 (current) - March 15, 2026: Escalation threshold updated to include Code 4 in addition to Code 5. Photographic evidence rule added to section 5. Code 4 description revised to specify 15 cm rut depth threshold.

v2.2 - July 20, 2025: Minor wording updates to Code 3 description.

v2.1 - February 10, 2025: Code 2 threshold clarified with 5 cm rut depth language. Recommended action for Code 3 updated.

v1.9 - January 10, 2024: Prior active version. Superseded by v2.1.

END OF DOCUMENT
